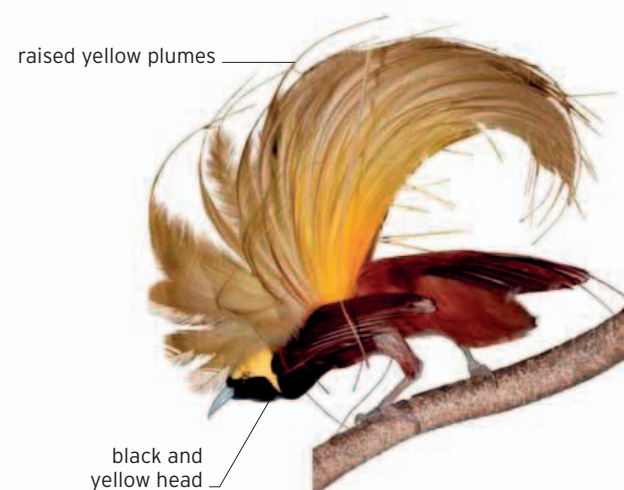


Greater bird-of-paradise

Paradisaea apoda



More than 40 species of birds-of-paradise survive today, almost all in the dense forests of New Guinea, although a few extend into Indonesia and northern Australia. The greater bird-of-paradise is the largest in its family, and is roughly the size and shape of a crow, with strong, scaly legs and feet and a pointed beak. It is chiefly vegetarian, eating fruit and seeds as well as a few small insects.

Some species are relatively drab and form stable breeding pairs. Others are polygynous, with the more ornate males mating with several females. The males of these species boast beautiful feathers that have evolved into many kinds of plumes and springlike shafts, loops, spirals, and extensive iridescent shawls. Male greater birds-of-paradise have spectacular plumes that extend back from their flank, but which can be raised and spread, giving the impression that their whole body is adorned with long, wide sickles of maroon, white, and golden yellow. The females are dark maroon-brown and free of such eye-catching adornments.

Display perches

The males of polygynous species display at special sites called leks, where females assess their remarkable courtship dances and choose only the brightest, fittest

males to mate with. A greater bird-of-paradise lek consists of large horizontal branches just below the canopy of a tall tree or trees. Adult males remove leaves from branches in the immediate area of the display perches, and the same site may be used for several years. Between eight and as many as 20 males use the same lek, and some leks may be shared with male raggiana birds-of-paradise (*P. raggiana*), which are similar in appearance.

Frenetic performance

Lekking male greater birds-of-paradise wave their wings and raise their long plumes, then briefly pose with spread plumes and arched, half-open wings. Competing males leap around each other, bouncing on a branch, flapping their wings and shaking their plumes. When they lean over and hang upside down, it is sometimes hard to tell which end is which. They keep up a chorus of loud, echoing *wa-wa-wa-wa-wah* sounds, while the females watch quietly then pick a favored male to mate with.

As with all the polygynous species, the male plays no part in nesting or the raising of young. The female builds a basin-shaped nest out of leaves and vine tendrils and lays one or two eggs.

Rumors of “visitors from paradise” reached Europe before these birds were first described by naturalists

◁ DAWN DISPLAY

During courtship, the male curves his yellow flank plumes over drooped wings and builds up to a trembling, shuddering performance designed to win a female's favors.

- ↔ 17–18 in (42–45 cm)
- ⚖ 6 oz (170 g)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🌿 Fruit, seeds, insects
- 🏠 🌳



SE. Asia, New Guinea